

Politics of Authoritarianism

01:790:342

Summer 2026 | Asynchronous Online

Department of Political Science | Rutgers University

Instructor	Pin Lu
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Office Hours	Fridays 2:00–3:30 PM ET via Zoom, or by appointment

Course Description

Authoritarianism is a long-standing form of political organization that today shapes the political lives of roughly half the world's population. This course takes authoritarian regimes as a subject in their own right: how elite power is organized, how regimes govern populations, how economies and societies operate under non-democratic rule, how opposition emerges and is managed, and how regimes change—including transitions in both democratic and authoritarian directions.

The course is structured around six thematic weeks, moving from foundational concepts to specific arenas of authoritarian politics, and finally to contemporary trends of authoritarianism. Throughout, the course engages cases from East Asia, the Middle East and North Africa, Latin America, Southern Africa, and Eastern Europe.

The course adopts an analytical comparative approach: students develop conceptual tools through readings and video lectures, then apply these tools to specific cases through weekly writing and a final video presentation.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- **Identify and describe** the main types of authoritarian regimes and how their core institutions sustain non-democratic rule.
- **Compare and apply** course concepts to authoritarian regimes across multiple world regions, identifying both common patterns and regional variation in authoritarian governance.
- **Interpret** contemporary phenomena involving authoritarianism by the use of course concepts to develop evidence-based interpretations.

Course Design

The six weeks follow a cumulative sequence. Week 1 establishes the vocabulary of the course: how regimes are classified and how autocratization is measured. Week 2 turns to the institutions through which rulers manage elites and organize support, namely parties and elections. Week 3 adds the economic dimension, asking whether and under what conditions authoritarian rule produces development. Week 4 brings society into view, examining collective action under high risk and the ways states justify

repression. Week 5 examines distribution and social policy as tools regimes use to secure compliance, complementing the coercion studied in Week 4. Week 6 closes with regime change in both directions, drawing on the institutional, economic, and societal factors covered in earlier weeks to understand why democracies erode and autocracies break down.

The assignments build analytical skills in stages. Political science is learned by doing analysis rather than by memorizing conclusions, so each assignment practices one component of analysis that the final project brings together. Reading annotations train basic analytical moves through five lenses: posing questions, tracking concepts, checking evidence, connecting readings, and linking to real-world cases. Weekly critical responses ask students to take a position on a claim and support it with evidence. The project outline and one-on-one meeting help each student focus a question and match it to relevant concepts and cases. The final video presentation carries out a complete analysis, from an analytical question to an evidence-based answer.

Course cases come from East Asia, the Middle East and North Africa, Latin America, Southern Africa, and Eastern Europe. Students are encouraged to work with cases they know, including those from their own countries or communities, and to set them against cases from other regions. This comparison lets students see the political environment they know as one configuration among many, and identify which features of authoritarian rule recur across regions and which are specific to particular settings.

Course Format

This is an intensive asynchronous online course running over six weeks. As a 3-credit summer course, the weekly workload is equivalent to two weeks of work in a regular fall or spring semester. Each week:

- **Monday:** Video lectures and reading assignments released on Canvas.
- **Friday at 11:59 PM ET:** Reading annotations on Perusall due.
- **Sunday at 11:59 PM ET:** Weekly Lecture Critical Response (and any other Canvas assignments) due.

The project outline (Week 4) and the final video presentation are scheduled at designated times.

The instructor holds weekly office hours via Zoom (Fridays 2:00–3:30 PM ET) and is available by appointment.

Required Materials

All readings will be made available on Perusall as PDFs. No textbook purchases are required.

The course includes 12 readings—two per week, approximately 50 pages per week.

Assignments and Grading

Assignment	Deadline (11:59 PM ET)	Points
Week 1: Self-Introduction + Photo	May 31	2
Week 1: AI Policy Discussion	May 31	1
Mid-term Course Evaluation	TBD	2
Weekly Reading Annotations (5 pts × 6 weeks)	Fridays	30

Weekly Lecture Critical Response (5 pts × 5 weeks)	Sundays	25
Week 4: Final Project Outline + 1-on-1 Meeting	June 21	15
Final Video Presentation	July 2	25
Total		100

Assignment Descriptions

Weekly Reading Annotations

Each week, students post 5 substantive annotations on the assigned readings using Perusall. Three of these must use three different analytical lenses from the list below—one annotation per lens, student's choice which three. The remaining two are free annotations on anything in the reading the student finds important.

- **QP — Question-Poser:** Pose a substantive question that opens analytical space—not yes-or-no.
- **CT — Concept-Tracker:** Examine one concept—its definition, measurement, or slippery edges.
- **EC — Evidence-Checker:** Evaluate one piece of evidence—does it really license the author's claim?
- **CC — Cross-Connector:** Connect to a specific earlier reading—name it. (Week 1 exception: connect to prior coursework or general knowledge.)
- **RL — Real-World Linker:** Connect to a real-world case beyond what the author discusses.

Lens annotations should be tagged with their codes (QP, CT, EC, CC, or RL) so the lens being used is clear. Full guidance for each lens is provided in the *Reading Annotation Guide* posted on Canvas. Students are expected to read the assigned material thoroughly and to engage actively with classmates' and the instructor's annotations.

To discourage mechanical compliance, the detailed grading rubric for this assignment is not disclosed. Students are invited to figure out for themselves what makes for higher grades.

Perusall is set to provide automated scoring, but the instructor reads every annotation, participates in the discussions, and makes the final grading determination.

Weekly Lecture Critical Response

Each week, students write a short analytical response (approximately 500 words) engaging with that week's video lecture. The task:

- Identify a substantive claim made in the video.
- Take a position: students may agree, question, or oppose.
- Support the position with evidence-based arguments.

Each student may skip one weekly response without advance notification.

Final Project Outline + 1-on-1 Meeting

By the end of Week 4, students submit a draft of their final project, including the analytical question they plan to address, the course concepts they intend to apply, and their provisional case material. Students then meet with the instructor individually (15 minutes via Zoom) to discuss the draft and refine the project before final recording.

Final Video Presentation

The final project is a 15-minute (minimum) recorded video presentation in which students pose an analytical question of their own design about authoritarianism and answer it using course concepts and cases. The question must be analytical (not descriptive), answerable using course material, and focused enough to address in 15 minutes.

Due: July 2, 11:59 PM ET

Course Schedule and Readings

Week 1: Regime Types and Measurement (May 26 – 31)

(a) Regime Classification and Typology

Geddes, Barbara, Joseph Wright, and Erica Frantz. 2014. "Autocratic Breakdown and Regime Transitions: A New Data Set." *Perspectives on Politics* 12(2): 313–331.

(b) Measurement and Global Trends

Lührmann, Anna, and Staffan I. Lindberg. 2019. "A Third Wave of Autocratization Is Here: What Is New About It?" *Democratization* 26(7): 1095–1113.

Week 2: Institutions, Parties, and Elections (June 1 – 7)

(a) Authoritarian Parties: Co-optation and Control

Magaloni, Beatriz, and Ruth Kricheli. 2010. "Political Order and One-Party Rule." *Annual Review of Political Science* 13: 123–143.

(b) Authoritarian Elections and Competitive Authoritarianism (Jordan)

Lust-Okar, Ellen. 2006. "Elections under Authoritarianism: Preliminary Lessons from Jordan." *Democratization* 13(3): 456–471.

Week 3: Economy and Development (June 8 – 14)

(a) The Theoretical Debate on Authoritarianism and Economic Development

Olson, Mancur. 1993. "Dictatorship, Democracy, and Development." *American Political Science Review* 87(3): 567–576.

(b) Developmental Authoritarianism: The Korea Case

Kohli, Atul. 1994. "Where Do High Growth Political Economies Come From? The Japanese Lineage of Korea's 'Developmental State.'" *World Development* 22(9): 1269–1293.

Week 4: Protest and Repression (June 15 – 21)

(a) High-Risk Collective Action (Argentina, Chile, Uruguay)

Loveman, Mara. 1998. "High-Risk Collective Action: Defending Human Rights in Chile, Uruguay, and Argentina." *American Journal of Sociology* 104(2): 477–525.

(b) The State Side: Emotional Framing and the Legitimation of Repression (Iran)

Ranji, Banafsheh, and Kjetil Selvik. 2026. "Emotions in the Legitimation of Repression: State Framing during the Woman, Life, Freedom Movement in Iran." *International Political Science Review* 47(2): 283–298.

Week 5: Distributive Politics and Social Policy (June 22 – 28)

(a) Distribution as Cooptation (Angola)

Soares de Oliveira, Ricardo. 2011. "Illiberal Peacebuilding in Angola." *Journal of Modern African Studies* 49(2): 287–314.

(b) Social Policy as Governance (China)

Huang, Xian. 2015. "Four Worlds of Welfare: Understanding Subnational Variation in Chinese Social Health Insurance." *The China Quarterly* 222: 449–474.

Week 6: Democratic Backsliding and Authoritarian Breakdown (June 29 – July 2)

(a) Democratic Backsliding

Haggard, Stephan, and Robert Kaufman. 2021. "The Anatomy of Democratic Backsliding." *Journal of Democracy* 32(4): 27–41.

(b) Authoritarian Breakdown

Treisman, Daniel. 2020. "Democracy by Mistake: How the Errors of Autocrats Trigger Transitions to Freer Government." *American Political Science Review* 114(3): 792–810.

Course Policies

Late Work

- **Weekly reading annotations on Perusall:** Late submissions are not accepted.
- **Weekly Lecture Critical Response:** 10% is deducted per day late, up to a maximum of three days; after three days, no credit. Pre-approved extensions (arranged with the instructor in advance) are not penalized. Each student may also skip one response without penalty (see assignment description).
- **Final project:** Due to grade submission deadline constraints, the final project is not accepted late.

AI Use

The course AI policy will be created after student discussion (see Week 1 schedule).

Academic Integrity

This course follows Rutgers University's Academic Integrity Policy. All work submitted must be the student's own. Plagiarism, including AI-assisted writing or unauthorized collaboration in violation of the course AI policy, will result in academic sanctions. See <https://academicintegrity.rutgers.edu> for the full policy.

For any assignment suspected of violating this policy, the instructor may require a meeting with the student to discuss the work. Failure to attend will result in a grade of 0 for that assignment.

Communication

- Email: the instructor responds within 24 hours on weekdays and within 48 hours on weekends.
- Office hours: Fridays 2:00–3:30 PM ET via Zoom, or by appointment.